“With you by my side, nothing bad can happen. You’re my good luck __”

“Shh,” she whispered, pressing her lips to his. The rain fell harder.

“Let’s go under the stairs,” André said.

They ran across the walkway and stood under the elegant stairs attached to the grand building overlooking the gardens. The rain came down in heavy sheets. Rose’s dress was drenched. She shivered. He brought her close, enveloping her in his warmth.

“It’s beautiful here,” she said. “What’s this place called?”

“*Museumsinsel*—Museum Island. Behind us is the Altes Museum, built in the neoclassical style and overlooking the Lustgarten where we were just sitting.” He kissed her forehead. “Have you heard of it?”

“No, tell me about it.” She wanted to spend every day like this, in his arms, talking.

“Altes was designed by Friedrich Schinkel. Inside is a rotunda modelled on the Pantheon in Rome. We studied it at L’Ecole des Beaux-Arts.” He pointed in the direction of the bridge. “Farther along, there’s a stunning building designed by his student, Stüler. And on the other side of the river, a building by Alfred Messel that took twenty years to construct. All famous men in the world of architecture.” He sighed. “I fear none of these buildings will survive what’s coming.”

“The air raids?”

“They’ll blow Berlin to bits.”

“Must they?” she asked. It seemed such a terrible waste.

“The Allies can defeat the Wehrmacht on the battlefield. But to conquer the nation and its people, yes.”

“By destroying buildings?” Rose didn’t understand. “They’re only stone and glass.”

“But they hold a connection to Germany’s great past. Buildings are mirrors for people to look into and see their culture and identity reflected back. That’s why the French kings built Versailles and all the châteaux along the Loire River. People are fragile and die, but what a great nation builds lives on, passing from one generation to another.” He hugged her close. “If Berlin is destroyed, the Nazi ideology that triumphed here will end.”

Rose shuddered. How many people in Berlin and other German cities